VISUAL ARTS EDUCATION FORM 5 · TOPIC 6

From White Cloth to Rainbow

Exploring Malaysian Batik through Batik Pelangi



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What is batik?



A batik artist at work in the Jadi Batek workshop, Kuala Lumpur. Photo: Bahnfrend, CC BY-SA 4.0

Batik is cloth decorated by **waxing** and **dyeing** white fabric. **Wax is a colour resist:** the parts covered by wax do not take the dye, so the pattern stays clear.



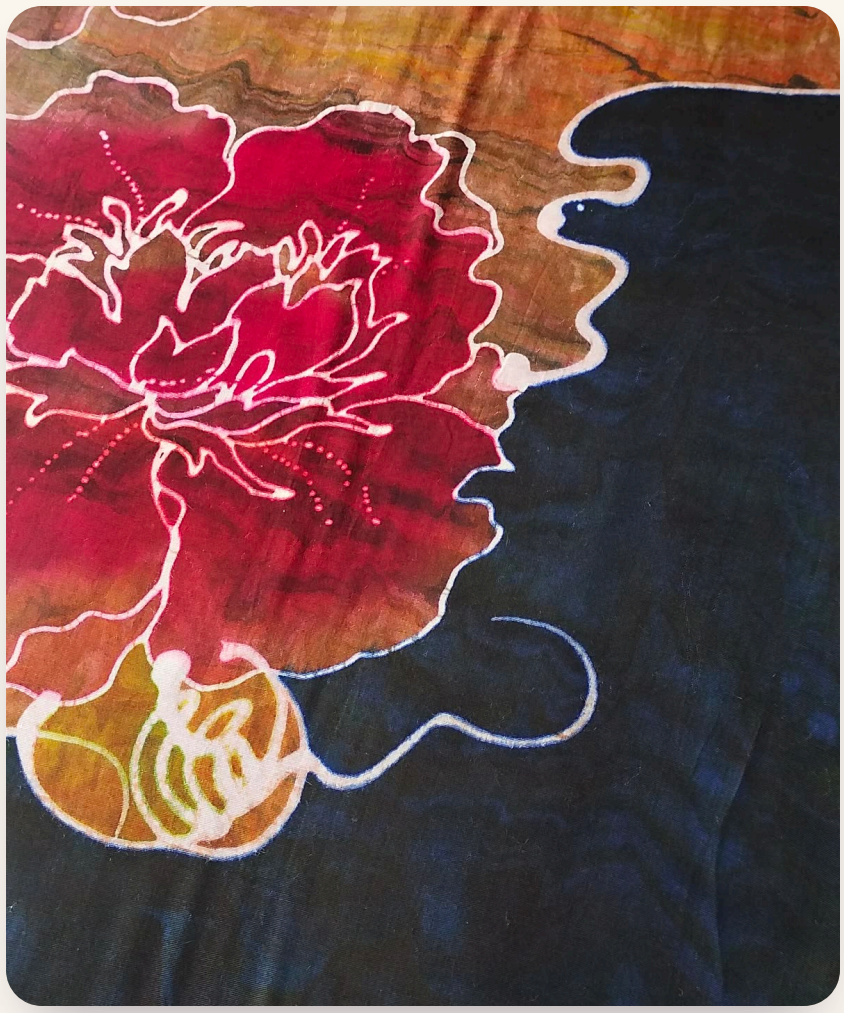
Dye is applied with a brush or by dipping. Today batik is made into shirts, scarves, shawls and home décor, not just sarongs.

Two methods, one colour-resist principle. Wax-resist batik (canting, block, screen) uses **wax** to block the dye. **Batik Pelangi** uses **tie-dye without wax**: the cloth is tied so the dye cannot soak into the tied parts.

From Terengganu and Kelantan



Batik Terengganu. Karnival Komuniti Kraf 2025, Kuala Lumpur. Photo: Rulwarih, CC BY-SA 4.0



Terengganu batik kaftan with a flower motif. Photo: Rulwarih, CC BY-SA 4.0

IN THE TEXTBOOK Kelantan and Terengganu are the **pioneer** states of batik craft in Malaysia, and **Batik Pelangi** is described as the oldest batik in our country.

TERENGGANU

Minah Pelangi

associated with early **kain pelangi** production in Terengganu

KELANTAN

Haji Che Su

contributed to the **batik enterprise** and **block-printing** development in Kelantan

Historical note: the roles of both figures are explained from broader historical records, not only the textbook.

A symbol of Malaysian identity. Batik is recognised as one symbol of Malaysian identity. It is not the only national attire, as Malaysia also has many traditional costumes of other communities.

Basic principles of batik

1. **Wax covers** the pattern areas so the dye cannot soak in.
2. **The cloth is dyed** by brushing or dipping.
3. **The wax is removed** and the pattern appears on the cloth.



Canting: drawing a pattern on cloth with hot wax (Cirebon, **Indonesia**). The same technique is studied in Seni Batik. Photo: Ahaetulla, CC BY-SA 4.0

Another technique: tie-dye uses **ties**, not wax, to block the dye. This is the basis of Batik Pelangi.

What makes batik beautiful?

Rhythm and movement
leaves and stems that curve and creep

Variety
different motifs and colours in one cloth

Emphasis
the head panel is the focal point of a sarong

Harmony
repeated motifs stylised in a consistent way

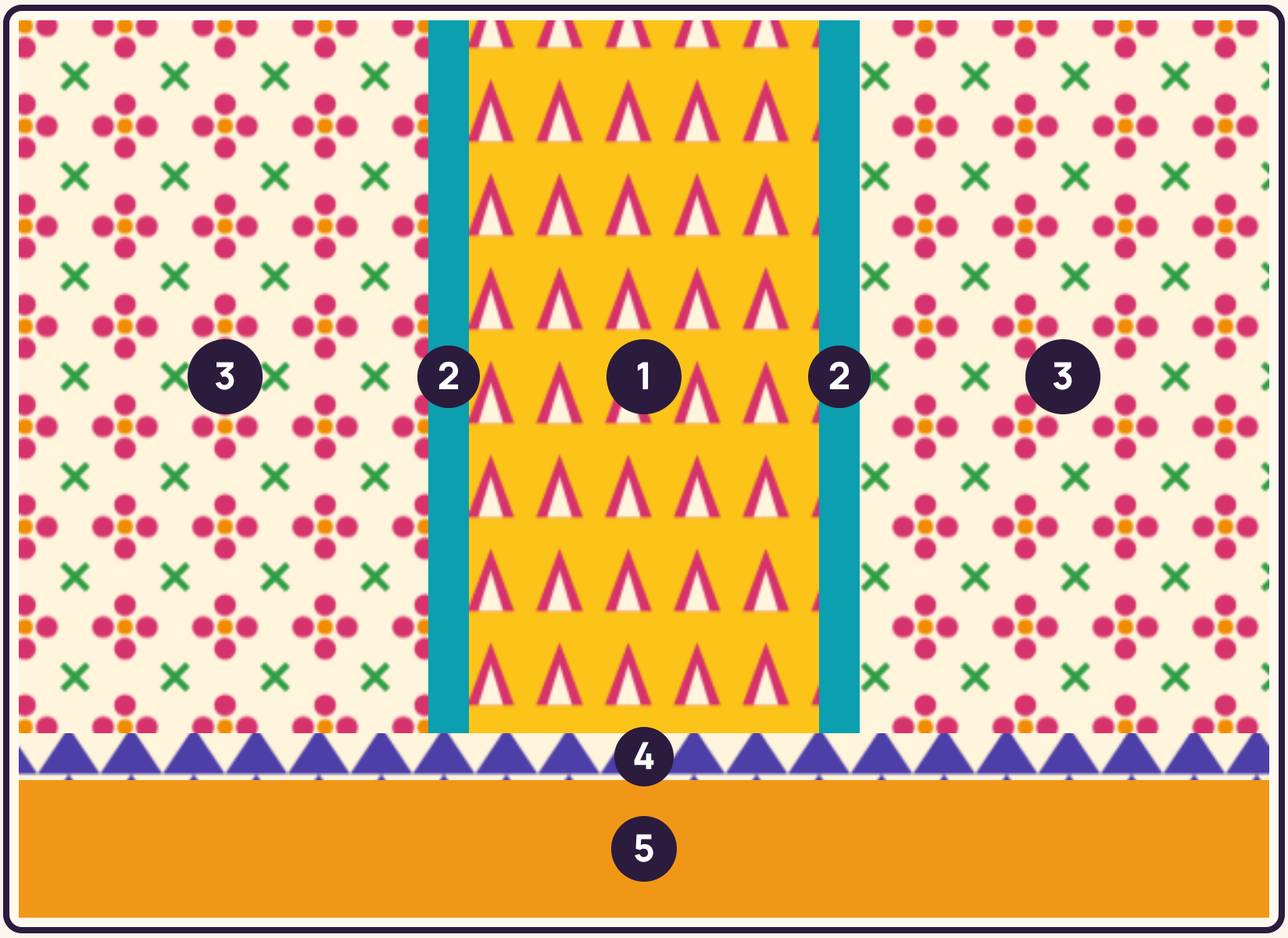
Balance
balanced shapes of the pattern across the cloth



Malaysian hand-drawn batik cloth with many motifs. Photo: Apluswiki, CC BY-SA 4.0

The quality of batik is judged by the **accuracy of the wax lines** and the **neatness of the colouring**.

Know the parts of a batik cloth



Simple diagram of a batik sarong (original illustration)

1. **Head panel (kepala kain):** about 12 to 18 inches (excluding the borders), usually with pucuk rebung or plant motifs.
2. **Head-panel borders (pengapit kepala kain):** the cloth edges with small motifs.
3. **Body (badan kain):** motifs and colours match the head panel.
4. **Teeth (gigi kain):** tooth-like motifs near the foot.
5. **Foot (kaki kain):** the bottom part of the sarong.

Four types of batik motif



FLORA

pucuk rebung (bamboo shoot), Siti Fatimah leaf, lotus, rose

Batik Pahang. Photo: Rulwarih, CC BY-SA 4.0



FAUNA

birds, chickens, butterflies, snails

AI illustration (ChatGPT)



GEOMETRIC

banji, kawung, stripes

AI illustration (ChatGPT)



ABSTRACT

mega mendung (rain clouds), fishing net, clouds

AI illustration (ChatGPT)



Isen motifs fill empty space as a background, for example cecek-cecek (dots) and sisik melik (dotted scales).

Motif arrangements: upright, lattice, striped, checkered, horizontal or diagonal.

Malay batik pattern (vector). EmpAhmadK, CC0

Four types of batik



BATIK PELANGI

Tie-dye, no wax. Commonly for shirts, headscarves and sashes.

AI illustration (ChatGPT): a modern example of rainbow tie-dye, not a historical depiction of traditional Batik Pelangi.



BATIK CANTING

A canting is filled with **molten wax** to draw patterns. Commonly for shawls, scarves and ties.

Cirebon, Indonesia. Photo: Ahaetulla, CC BY-SA 4.0



BATIK BLOCK (CAP)

Patterns are **stamped** with a metal block. In the textbook process, three colours use three blocks; this is not a rule for every design.

Copper block, National Museum of Indonesia. Photo: G. Kartapranata, CC BY-SA 3.0



BATIK SCREEN

Cool wax and a silk screen. Produces uniform images again and again.

AI illustration (ChatGPT)

Compare: Batik Pelangi uses ties; Canting, Block and Screen use wax as the colour resist.

Tools and materials



AI illustration (ChatGPT)

TOOLS

1 String or thread
2 Rubber bands
3 Marbles
4 Utility knife
5 Brush

MATERIALS

6 Cotton or satin silk cloth
7 Remazol dye, yellow
8 Remazol dye, blue
9 Remazol dye, red
10 Sodium silicate

Did you know? The white cloth is washed first to remove starch so the dye soaks in easily.

Chemical safety: work under **teacher supervision**. Wear **gloves** and **eye protection**, and work in a **well-ventilated area**. Keep dyes and sodium silicate off skin and eyes, and follow the manufacturer's safety labels.

Naphthol dye can also be used and needs no colour-fixing step.

Batik Pelangi: steps 1 to 4



AI illustration (ChatGPT)

1 Tie

Put **marbles** into the cloth and tie them with string or rubber bands in the pattern you want.

2 Prepare dye

Prepare **Remazol** dye to colour the cloth.

The pattern depends on the tie: marbles and stones make **circles**, stitching makes a **dotted** effect.



3 Dye

Dip the cloth or brush dye onto the tied parts. *Tip: dampen the cloth first so the colour soaks in.*

Cloth tied and dyed in a dye bath. Photo: Johann H. Addicks, CC BY-SA 3.0



4 Add colour

Use several colours for a rainbow pattern, then leave it to dry.

Ties after dyeing. Photo: Johann H. Addicks, CC BY-SA 3.0

Batik Pelangi: steps 5 to 8



5 Untie

Untie the cloth once it is dry.

6 Fix colour

Soak the cloth in **sodium silicate** for about **5 hours** (as stated in the KSSM textbook).

7 Wash

Wash until clean to remove leftover sodium silicate.

8 Dry

Dry it in a **shady place**.

Important: actual processing time depends on the **dye manufacturer's guidance** and **teacher supervision**.

AI illustration (ChatGPT): a modern example of rainbow tie-dye, not a historical depiction of traditional Batik Pelangi.



Final result: Batik Pelangi!

An illustrative modern swirl tie-dye pattern. Photo: Desmont4joy, CC BY-SA 4.0

SUMMARY

What did we learn?

1. Batik is a heritage craft that uses a **colour resist** (wax or ties).
2. Batik has **parts of the cloth** and **four motif categories**.
3. Batik Pelangi is made in **8 steps** of tie-dye.

Test yourself

1. Who is associated with Batik Pelangi in Terengganu and Kelantan? *(Minah Pelangi: kain pelangi in Terengganu; Haji Che Su: batik enterprise and block printing in Kelantan)*
2. What does wax do in batik? *(it stops the colours from mixing)*
3. How long is the cloth soaked in sodium silicate, per the textbook? *(about 5 hours; follow the manufacturer and teacher)*



Main reference: Kementerian Pendidikan Malaysia. (2020). *Pendidikan Seni Visual Tingkatan 5 KSSM* (Topic 6: Seni Batik, pp. 137–154). Pustaka Sarjana Sdn. Bhd. Textbook statements are distinguished from broader historical notes. (Used as a reference only; the text is written in the author's own words.)

Credits: text and layout by Claude (AI); illustrations by ChatGPT (AI); compiled by Lokman Hakim bin Yusoff.

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